The Dark Choice Of Heather

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If the world calls you a monster long enough,
one day you stop proving them wrong.

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Prologue

The night Heather was born, the sky was silent.

No storms. No thunder. No divine omen to mark the arrival of a child who would one day change the fate of many lives. The world continued as it always had—indifferent and unaware.

But fate had already begun its quiet work.

Before she became Heather, she was a girl with another name. A fragile child carried through places where innocence had no protection and kindness was a rare accident. The world she opened her eyes to was not gentle. It was filled with secrets whispered behind closed doors, shadows that watched silently, and people who believed survival mattered more than mercy.

For a long time, she did what any child would do.

She endured.

Years passed within the walls of a doctor's household—the Ellingsons. To outsiders, it was a respectable home. Orderly. Civilized. A place where people believed healing and discipline could keep darkness away.

But houses have cracks.

And through those cracks, the past always finds a way inside.

Heather grew up between silence and observation. She spoke little, listened too much, and learned quickly that people often hid their truest selves behind polite smiles. In that house lived others whose lives would intertwine with hers—Julian, whose quiet understanding mirrored the shadows within her, and Robert, distant and brilliant, shaped by a world of wealth and expectations.

They were a family.

Or something that pretended to be one.

Yet even then, something about Heather was… different.

Not cruel.

Not kind.

Just watching.

Waiting.

Because deep inside her, beyond the memories of hunger, loneliness, and quiet nights where no one noticed her existence, something darker was slowly taking root.

Not evil.

Not yet.

Just power waiting for the right moment to awaken.

And when that moment finally came, it would change everything.

The girl the world once ignored would disappear.

And in her place, Jade would rise.

Not a hero.
Not a villain.
Something far more dangerous.
Someone who no longer feared becoming the monster everyone already believed she was.

CHAPTER 1 : WHISPERS IN THE WATER

“Today is a wonderful day,” Heather whispered, eyes fixed on the sky above as the golden dusk spilled across the rooftops.
With quiet resolve, she climbed the ladder and perched herself on top of the tall stone wall, both legs dangling freely. From up there, she took one last look at the mansion behind her — the grand palace she once called home. She smiled, "I'm not coming back anymore."
And with a swift kick, she knocked the ladder down. It clattered against the stone with a loud bang, echoing like a declaration of war. She jumped.
The mansion faded behind her as she moved forward into the unknown.
Before her stood a thick forest, ancient and wild. But Heather was not afraid. She noticed faint trails on the ground — footprints that had worn a path through the dense brush. Without hesitation, she followed them.
Rich estates always had wide-open grounds.
This wasn’t the city, crowded and tangled — this was quiet, vast land.
But that silence made escaping harder. People knew her. Too many people.
She could have waited near the delivery route for a cart or hitched a ride into town. But not today. Today, she was running away. “Oh wow,” she chuckled to herself. “This is so cliché. Now it’s going to be fun.” Just ahead, an old bicycle stood leaning against a tree. She paused. "Hmm... I've never seen this here before." She looked around, scanning the empty road.
"What if someone comes back for it? What should I say?" Uneasy, she decided not to risk it. She left the bike behind and kept walking.
The road curved deeper into the woods, trees rising like ancient guards on either side. After some time, she reached a small settlement — a village corner bustling with life. She slipped in unnoticed among the common people. No one recognized her in her plain clothes and dusted hair. For once, she looked like everyone else. In the corner of the market, she spotted a familiar shop — a small food stall run by an old man and his daughter. They had known her, once, from a different world. She entered, careful not to draw attention. “Lulu, can I get some bread?” she asked gently. A red-haired girl stepped out, wiping her hands on her apron. “It’s

been a while, Heather. But I'm busy — I can't play with you today."
Heather gave a crooked smile and took her hand, pulling her gently into the store. She pointed at the shelves. "I'm not here to play. I'm here to buy. I'm not some useless girl." Lulu stared at her — at the look in her eyes — and nodded. The air between them changed. "What do you need, ma'am?"
Without hesitation, Heather grabbed a few things — bread, jam, candy, chips, and a small bag of rice. She paid, thanked them, and stepped back into the fading light. The sun was beginning to sink, but the road ahead was still visible. They said no more. Lulu returned to her chores. Heather returned to her escape. Deeper into the forest now, with no one in sight. The darkness came quickly. She had wandered far, far from anything familiar. Finally, she stopped. Beneath a cluster of thick trees, she set her bag down. For the first time in days, she allowed herself to breathe. Looking at the quiet wilderness around her, she smiled.
"I've always wanted to come here... but I never could. Now... I'm free."
She shouted the words into the sky, laughing with wild joy. And the night welcomed her like it had been waiting. The wind howled through the trees. .
Nothing ahead of her lay a serene lake, hidden between mountains like a secret kept by time itself. The water shimmered in the moonlight, glowing blue and soft, like glass under starlight. Heather stood still, mouth parted in awe. "Ah... ha... ha..." She couldn't find words. Suddenly—SPLASH! Something leapt beside her into the lake. A powerful splash broke the silence. She gasped and froze. There was someone—no, something—standing across the water from her. They locked eyes.
Despite the late hour, the moon was high and full, casting silver light across the lake. She could see him clearly.
Her golden eyes widened, a creature. Upright. Covered in fur, like a beast from stories—red, white, and black. Its breath is heavy. Its chest rising. Its eyes locked on hers. Blood stained its claws, but it stood still. Watching. Then—a flash. Something sparkled in the sky and dropped into the water like a star falling from heaven. Both Heather and the beast turned to look.
The lake glowed. Something flickered below the surface, shining like starlight. She stepped forward, mesmerized. It shimmered. Then—gone. Heather panicked. "Where did it go? That light—it... wha—what was that?!" She looked around. But now the creature is gone. The lake was still. "Wh-where did everyone go?!" She shouted into the silence, heart pounding.
But no answer came. Exhaustion swept over her like a heavy fog. Her body couldn't take it anymore. She fell asleep. The next morning, sunlight brushed against her cheek, gently waking her. She blinked, sat up, and looked one last time at the lake behind her. Then she moved on. Fields stretched far and wide, flowers blooming like carpets of color.

There were no roads, but Heather walked without stopping. The land felt endless, but beautiful. After walking through wildflower meadows for three days, Heather finally arrived at a small railway station. It was nearing dusk. There were barely any people—only a few vendors wandering around with trays of tea, coffee, and snacks, calling lazily for customers. Heather looked around, then walked to the ticket counter, It was empty, she glanced left and right. "Hey! What are you doing here, girl?" a loud, gruff voice called out. She turned around slowly. A heavy-set man stood behind her, squinting at her suspiciously.

She was small, just a child—ten years old. Her clothes were worn, stained with mud and travel. Her cheeks were smudged with dust.Her cap barely hid her uncombed hair. To the man, she didn't look like a normal child. She looked like a beggar. Heather stood tall, pretending confidence.

"I'm going to Liveland. To meet my mother," She said firmly. She had practiced this line many times before.

The man grunted and held out his hand for payment. Heather pulled out a few crumpled notes from her pocket. The man examined them, nodded, and gave her a ticket. He didn't believe her story, but he took the money. She sat down quietly to wait. People passed by her, glancing briefly, some with pity, some with disdain. No one talked to her. No one asked if she needed help. To them—she was just another poor child trying to get somewhere. The train was late. And when the engine finally screamed in the distance, Heather looked up, hope flickering in her tired eyes. The train arrived — mostly empty. A few women and children stepped down. Heather watched closely, eyes scanning. Then she heard it.

"Alright now, time for the money!".

Heather barely had time to glance up.

In an instant — a strong hand clamped over her mouth, dragging her back into the shadows behind the pillar. The other man followed, helping to hold her struggling body. She kicked. She tried to scream. But the cloth in his hand was damp. It smelled strange. Her limbs weakened. Her heart raced. The last thing she saw was the train lights flickering in the distance before… Darkness.

Two men, dressed well and carrying a large suitcase, stepped off the train but Heather didn't notice them.

She was watching the children laughing with their mothers, and the women leaving with their luggage.

Sitting there in the light, Heather wasn't hard to recognize. Before she could react, both men pressed a poisonous cloth over her mouth. Because the train was nearly empty, very few people were around to see it.

The two men stuffed her into a large suitcase and quietly carried it away. Three nights and two days later, they reached a city known for *burning corpses*.

They travelled quickly by train and bus.

Inside the suitcase, Heather hadn't made a single sound. One of the two — a young man around 20 years old — finally broke the silence, glancing down at the suitcase with a softer expression. "Don't you think this girl might be dead by now?" Hearing this, the taller, muscular man sitting next to him — who was five years older than his younger brother — replied "Don't talk like an idiot! We need that money badly — if we don't pay the rent, we won't even have a house left!"

As he scolded his younger brother, the older one glanced around — it had rained heavily, and the mud had shifted off the path, revealing the stone trail beneath. Just then, a man clearing the path looked up at them and said,

"They've been waiting for you two."

Nearby, a wooden cart stood ready to carry the cargo. The younger brother (Huan) grabbed the older one's hand tightly, nervously staring at the man.

The older brother (Lian) stepped forward and spoke firmly: "We brought her exactly as instructed." The man — who was responsible for hauling supplies up from the base — didn't say a word.

He lifted the suitcase into the cart, and they began the long climb up the hill. At the top stood an old stone mansion, built into pink and yellow cliffs. It had once been called "The Garden of Stone", but now it went by another name: "The Crimson Veil."

After several minutes of hauling, they reached the gates. Beautiful flowers grew all around the path leading in — tangled vines and blooming branches weaving through everything like nature reclaiming the ruins.

The mansion overlooked the vast land below — a place that would mesmerize anyone who saw it. At the entrance stood two figures: a young man supporting an old man, the elder was the master of the house.

As the three men approached, they were greeted by an older woman, pacing in circles. The moment she saw them, she turned red with anger. "Three days! Huh! You two were supposed to arrive by last night! "Before she could speak further, the old man raised his hand silently — a signal for her to quiet down.

Several others were present — young women, gathered to see what had been brought. One of them said coldly: "Open it up. Let's see her."Lian stepped forward and unlatched the suitcase. The chains were tight. The cart-puller helped unlock it, and called out in surprise. Inside, Heather's hands and feet were bound, her body painfully twisted. Her hair was tangled in the metal latches. She was completely unconscious.

They pulled her out and dropped her onto the ground. Lian exhaled deeply and reached out his hand — the old woman said nothing, but placed a bundle of cash into it, made from thick, bound bills.

Chapter 2 :The party

"I never wanted to buy this trouble in the first place. Haider had been like this for three days now—absolute ruin. First, that crafty one drove me mad, and now this. A stick snapped through the air with a crack! and struck Heather . His life was extinguished before my eyes. His sobs—those dreadful, stifled cries—were too much for that old hag to bear. Then, taking even more money from me, she threw that little duck into the river…!"

She gave her a sharp slap, pressing Heather's face down as she hissed, "If you know nothing, shut your beak!" Once the little girl collapsed to the ground, she stopped crying.At the door stood three more girls, having overheard the commotion. Biba, her voice suddenly gentle, spoke up: "That's enough, Biba."

Clinging to the door frame was a twenty-year-old girl who had just arrived at the sound of the stick. Behind her appeared a plump, short man—the cook—muttering, "Today, she simply must work…"Just then, Siru, one of the other girls, said, "Oh! I remembered—I too came to summon Biba; they must have arrived already."

Biba stepped forward, excited, and signaled to the cook. Everyone else departed—only the cook and Heather remained. "Now, come on," she added. The cook strode ahead with Heather following closely behind. The ground floor was quite large, lined with numerous rooms. They passed from one corridor to another until they reached a filthy area. The floor was soaked with water everywhere, and puddles gleamed underfoot. Leftover food was scattered all over the kitchen. Two other boys were busy working there.

"Alright, clean this mess now," the cook said, glancing at Heather. "Ha ha ha, does he even know what he's doing?" One lad sneered while looking at Heather. The cook frowned and responded, "You'll teach her that until Milu and I finish the rest of the job..."

"Why?!" Lilu shouted in anger.

"Because you burned the chicken breast," the cook snapped, twisting his mouth in disapproval. With that, he stomped off to start cooking, leaving Heather to sweep up the mess.

"Okay, now take the broom over there," Lilu barked, tossing the broom aside. Heather slowly began clearing the trash.

"Quickly, move your hands, come on!" Lilu urged, impatient. He didn't

bother to clean thoroughly but rushed through the task and stepped out. Heather continued cleaning.

"I've done this before," she thought. She knew well how to tidy up; nothing here was entirely unfamiliar.

Meanwhile, the sitting room had been splendidly decorated: yellow and pink walls adorned with blue and red flowers, their stems draped with garlands. The cushions on the divan and the velvet orange sheets covering the seats were neatly arranged. Queen-colored pillows were carefully placed all around. In the center stood a table bearing beautiful white roses. The entire arrangement gave the impression of a separate space meant for just five guests. At the door, the mistress stood waiting, accompanied by six other girls who were there to assist with hospitality.

"They should be arriving any moment now..."

"This is the first time I've seen them come in the morning."

Clients usually came under the cover of night. All the deals, all the games in the brothel — followed the rules of darkness. That's why the old madam was restless today.But there was a strange smile on her face."Whoever it is, I won't let them go so easily this time... hee hee hee!"

She called out loudly, "Joone!"Then added, "Lirly, Karu, Anish!"Within moments, three girls stepped out one by one. Anish was already standing silently in the corner, her eyes lowered.Then…

From the hills came the sound of tires skidding against stone.

The rumble of a car engine pierced through the air.A long, black luxury car came to a halt in front of the large gate. Four more cars followed behind it.From the first car, a driver stepped out and opened the door. A young man emerged, around 22 years old.As soon as he stepped out, all the servants and women bowed their heads in greeting.

He walked forward with regal arrogance, his friends following closely behind.

But the old madam stood tall, chest forward, unshaken.

She smiled slyly like a fox and said,

"Today, you must treat my friends very well."

The young man smirked and replied,

"Then today your pockets are going to be emptied."

The madam smiled too, though caution flickered in her eyes."I could buy this entire brothel if I wanted to," he laughed loudly and walked past.No one dared stop him — because he wasn't just any customer. He was Cooper Jr., a spoiled rich boy,

who used his father's money to toy with the innocence of underage girls. The girls he chose... were never the same again. Inside, everyone had already settled in. Refreshments were served. Drinks poured. The usual greetings exchanged.

The old woman asked quietly,

"What kind of girl are you looking for, Mr. Cooper?"

Cooper gestured to one of his men. A slim suitcase was placed in front

of them. Opening it, Cooper said casually, "This should be enough."The madam's eyes briefly flashed with irritation, but she smiled as if unfazed."No sir... girls are very expensive these days."

"Rich families pay high prices — sometimes taking 15 or 20 girls in one go."Cooper scowled. "Do you think I can't afford that?"She didn't answer — only gave a signal with her hand. Everyone stepped aside. A servant walked down the hallway toward the rooms and signaled the girls.He grumbled to himself,

"Ugh... this trouble again." He didn't enter. Instead, five girls stepped out and lined up in front of the guests. Among the four men seated, whispers began: "She looks old..."

"Must be at least 30..."

"Not very attractive either..."

"Yeah, exactly."

Cooper was furious this time.

Every time he came, he demanded only virgin girls —but today, for the first time, he brought a large group with him.The girls were terrified, afraid he might kill them. Some refused to even appear in front of him.

Many stuffed garlic in their mouths so no one would pick them. Others faked menstrual cycles to avoid selection. Even then, Cooper didn't force anyone against their will — but the old madam had suffered too many financial losses in recent years. So now, she was cautious."This is just the beginning," she thought to herself.

"The rest are getting ready for you."

Night was approaching. The kitchen was still buzzing with activity — guests kept demanding food, and their requests just wouldn't stop.The cook, who had been working since morning, was furious — aggressively stirring dishes that were already fully cooked. The girls had grown tired after dancing non-stop — some had already returned to their rooms, but a few men were still in the hall, drunk and dancing.Heather had been cleaning since morning. Even though she had been scolded 2–3 times, she didn't give up — this time, she stood her ground.

The old madam, pacing through the corridor, walked out and directly addressed Cooper:

"Mister, are you and your guests staying the night?"

"We need to know — preparations must be made."Cooper, high on alcohol, smoke, and opium, barely responded. But the old woman knew — this was the perfect time to line her pockets.

There was a girl sitting in Cooper's lap. She gently moved and asked him,

"Are you staying here tonight?" He laughed lazily and said,

"Of course, darling... I'm here all night!" The intoxication had taken over.

No one was fully conscious — even those in the rooms were deep into their drunken pleasures.The old madam walked straight through the

corridor
and entered the kitchen, checking what was going on there…
The entire kitchen was a mess — food scattered everywhere, plates and liquor bottles lying around. There were three or four servants present, but with constant demands and orders, it had become nearly impossible to maintain cleanliness. Something new was being cooked every moment.
The old woman screamed at the top of her lungs,
"Cook! Where the hell are you? Come out!"
The cook, who was chopping vegetables, stepped forward with a spoon in his hand and said tiredly,
"Now you want something too? Just tell me and I'll make it."
His voice was heavy with exhaustion. He didn't have the strength to argue anymore.The old woman held a small white pouch in her hand. She grinned and held it up. The cook smiled for a second, then snatched the pouch from her and returned to his station without another word. Meanwhile, Heather was still sweeping the floor, silently gathering the trash. The old woman looked at her and snapped,
"Only after getting beaten do you work properly, huh? If you'd done this earlier, I wouldn't have had to beat you! Stupid little duck!"
Another woman was washing dishes in the kitchen. Seeing Heather just sweeping, she slammed the utensils hard in anger — though she was careful not to break anything, fearing the old woman's wrath. She marched over and slapped Heather hard, yelling,
"You've been ignoring me this whole time! My hands are aching — and you're just loitering around?"
Heather stood frozen, unable to respond. The woman continued angrily,
"Because of you, I'm stuck washing all the dishes. My hands are ruined — look at them!" Her hands, having been in cold water for too long, were pale and bruised. Enraged, she snatched the broom from Heather's hand, pushed her roughly, and shouted,
"Go wash the dishes now! I'm done!"
Without a word, Heather slowly got up and moved toward the sink. She had no other choice. She didn't know how to properly wash dishes, but she tried. Her small hands slipped over the wet utensils. Tears streamed silently down her cheeks and fell onto the dishes. Despite the pain, shame, and exhaustion — she wiped her own tears and kept washing, one dish at a time.
An hour later, when the old woman returns to the main hall, she sees that everyone is still there — dancing, laughing, drinking. She loudly announces,
*"It's time to eat, everyone — get ready!"*But no one listens to her.She then gestures to the girls sitting near the guests. Quietly understanding the signal, they rise and walk down the corridor toward the kitchen. The old

woman follows behind. Just as she reaches the kitchen door, a servant steps out suddenly. They nearly collide, but he quickly says, *"Everything's ready, madam!"* Upon hearing that, the old woman claps loudly — and the rest of the servants jump into action. Some head into the kitchen to fetch the food, others carry special wine glasses.

The plates were filled with a variety of rich, flavorful dishes. But *there was no water served — only wine,* and that too, *laced with the old woman's special drug.* The girls, following the silent command they were given, now begin to serve the food and wine to each guest — slowly, one by one. Despite the celebration, the old woman remained tense. *Two men were still upstairs with three women.* Worried, she turns to a servant and instructs him to go check *what's going on in those rooms.*

Chapter 3 : Night Fall Out

The feast was over. The kitchen staff had hauled all the cauldrons and leftover food back from the guests. The cook had already washed his hands and fled to his quarters. Only Milu, Lilu, and Heather remained; The crisp scent of cold water mingled with the sickening stench of rotting leftovers, making it hard to breathe. Haider labored over the dishes, a monumental task for her. Moonlight glinted sharply in her eyes. She paused, drew a deep breath, and stepped back, her hands numb. *Mother left first, then Father... I never imagined this. If you were still here, I wouldn't be running...* Hot tears welled in her reddened eyes, spilling down her cheeks and onto her lips. Hunger gnawed at her; she hadn't eaten in days. Six days of emptiness had hollowed her stomach, her ribs stark against her skin.

Kneeling amidst the mess, a sound broke the silence – footsteps, accompanied by a faint *chhan-chhan*. *Who's there now?* It was Anish. She heard Heather's soft weeping. "Oh, it's you. They've all gone," Anish remarked. Heather stood abruptly and resumed scrubbing. "I need drinking water," Anish demanded. Heather rinsed her hands and fetched it. Anish took a deep gulp. "Use that pipe over there. It'll speed things up. Don't use so much soap though, or she'll rage." She left, taking the glass.

Heather eyed the pipe. *Should I listen?* She glanced at the mountain of dishes, then picked up the hose and turned the tap. Nothing. *No water?* Suddenly, water gushed out, hitting her full in the face, soaking her clothes. "Hah!" Laughing despite herself, she aimed the pipe at a plate. It sparkled clean instantly. "Wow! Heh!" A genuine smile touched her lips for the first time. She works swiftly now. Cleaning, rinsing, stacking. It took time, but finally, it was done. Relief washed over her.

Inside, chaos reigned. Trash piled high. Her stomach growled. *"I actually enjoyed that!"* Humming a soft tune, she grabbed the hose and marched back into the kitchen, spraying water everywhere. Soon, the floor was a shallow lake. Heather worked frantically to contain the flood. She shut off the water, snatched a broom, and pushed the water out. *"Surely there's some food left... They were eating..."* Finding nothing, she stepped outside. The night air felt cleansing. With no one to stop her, she felt a

surge of freedom. An escape route beckoned.
Heather pushed open the gate and stepped into the whispering night. A strong wind rustled the trees, sending leaves dancing. Somewhere, a frog croaked. Her eyes caught the silhouette of a fruit tree. She approached, but the lowest branch was beyond her reach. Defeated, she sank onto a cool, flat stone by the water's edge, turning her face to the moon. "You're the only one left who might listen. Are you listening? Haa huh... What should I do?" The wind whipped her hair around her face. "Should I run? Or stay? It's impossible. Grandma said... Mother sold me. She took so much money for me..." Memories flooded back, making her hands tremble. "I'm not brave enough. But if Dad finds out... he'll be furious. He always shouted when I made mistakes..." She gazed into the dark water, shimmering under the moon's cold light. Midnight approached.
A rustle came from nearby bushes. Her attention snapped towards the sound. The shadows beneath the trees seemed deeper, more mysterious. Curiosity, a spark she couldn't suppress, flared within her. She stumbled towards the bushes, bracing herself on a rock as dizziness washed over her. "I need to see..." Pushing the foliage aside, she peered in. "Who's there?!" "Meow... Meow..." A tiny kitten emerged – black and white. Heather sighed deeply. "Oh, you scared me!" The kitten rubbed against her ankles. "Where's your mama?" Heather stroked its soft fur with her fingers. As she stood and turned, she froze. *Someone else was there.*

A girl. Long brown hair. Staring at the moon, just as Heather had been. Heather approached cautiously. "Who are you? When did you come?" The girl seemed unaware, lost in the lunar glow. Heather leaned against the stone. "It's beautiful, isn't it?" Their eyes met. The girl's eyes were pools of absolute black. Strange, pale marks marred her face. "Are you hurt? Your eyes... they're incredible!" They held each other's gaze. Heather swayed, suddenly weak. But the girl – Rosie – moved with preternatural speed, catching Heather before she hit the ground with just one hand. The black-and-white kitten meowed plaintively at their feet. It looked hungry too.
Rosie, slightly taller than Heather, effortlessly lifted her. She carried her towards the house, the kitten trailing behind and settling just outside the door with a soft *thump*. Rosie held Heather close, then did something strange: she gently licked the tear tracks on Heather's cheek. Heather flinched; the salty taste clearly displeased Rosie, who made a small grimace. Rosie carried Heather back to the stone beneath the tree, laid her down gently, and then... vanished into the night with her kitten.

As soon as dawn broke, the old woman woke up abruptly—or perhaps she hadn't slept peacefully all night. She roused all the servants early. Every morning, she would sit in her garden, sipping tea first thing, but

today, she went to the rooms were Cooper and his friends were. The room was in disarray. Last night, when they had all been unconscious, the old woman had locked them inside. He was her servant.
"Why are you here?" she demanded.
"They're supposed to go home today, so I came to wake them… but they won't get up!"
"Tell their families they didn't pay," she snapped. "Say you're taking them home yourself."
The servant said nothing and stepped out. The room bore stains of blood—even Cooper Jr.'s hands were smeared with it. He was still asleep.
Just then, another servant approached the old woman, whispering into her ear. She followed him to another room where the girls who worked the night shifts lay. The space was vast, lined with long beds, each occupied by seven girls. Other women lingered around them, some tending to the girls.
"Madam, Riaa's condition is critical. The bleeding won't stop—what should we do?"
Huri had been searching for the old woman earlier. Upon hearing this, the old lady shrieked, "You're just waiting for her to die! Go call the doctor, now!" The servant fled in fear.
"Where is Riaa? I need to see her!" the old woman yelled again.
Another girl spoke up timidly, "Madam, Liaa's chest is in terrible pain… and Nilua—her whole body is raw and bruised." She doesn't speak a word, seething with anger as she storms downstairs and orders her servant, "Go fetch that driver at once!" Shyam rushes off and soon returns with the driver. "I've already told them everything," the old woman mutters, but the driver leaves without another word.
The elderly woman is deeply troubled, her hands trembling as she clutches her own head in despair. Just then, the servant speaks up, "Why don't you lock him in a room? Don't let him leave until he pays back every last coin. Then watch how his brother comes running here to rescue him—only after returning your money!"
The old woman ponders the servant's words, her mind racing. *If I let him go, he'll never repay me. And what about the girls who suffered losses? Who will compensate them?* The weight of her worries presses down on her. "The intoxication of liquor will wear off soon anyway," she finally says. "It's best if you move him to a separate room quickly so the other four can leave."
The servant, too, is anxious about his own money. In this place where dreams are stifled by necessity, everyone is consumed by their own financial struggles. Some work for others, some scrape by for themselves—but in the end, everyone is fighting their own battles.

Meanwhile, Huari helps Riaa out of the bathroom to see the doctor, but

Riaa's condition is dire. She can barely stand, let alone walk. Blood pours from her body, staining the floor—if she steps out, the rest of the room will be ruined.

"You shouldn't have gone to him," Huari scolds, clutching a blood-soaked cloth in her hands. Riaa weakly grasps Huari's wrist, her voice trembling. "I don't know… something feels terribly wrong. But I had to go—no customers in days. You know what Madam would've done to me if I didn't…"

Tears stream down Riaa's face, her pain raw and visible. Huari gently strokes her cheek, whispering, "This isn't the time to think about that."

The doctor takes longer than expected to arrive. There was another man—an old physician—but he had fallen gravely ill. People had gone to call for him, but he wasn't there. So they waited, helpless, for another doctor to come.In the kitchen, everyone was beginning to prepare breakfast and snacks. The head cook and his assistant arrived, eager to avoid the mistress's wrath if anything was late. Since the palace's elderly master was frequently ill, meals had to be ready on time—so the old woman barked orders at everyone.

Nilu went out to the courtyard and returned with his hands full of scrap. He froze, staring behind the bushes. "What… what is that?" he cried. "Is there a dead body here? Who's died?"

His shout jolted Heather awake—he had been sleeping nearby, and the morning sun was brightening enough to reveal her face. Rubbing her eyes, she sat up and stood. Startled by Nilu's alarm, everyone rushed out. But to their relief and surprise, it was Heather, drenched, her hair wet and clinging to her shoulders.

A collective gasp filled the courtyard—until the cook recognized her. "That's not a dead body, it's a living one," he said, shaking his head. "Look more carefully—it's that foolish girl."

They all shifted their gaze to Heather, who stood shivering in her wet clothes. There was a collective sigh.

Nilu, scolded, retorted, "You're always acting out—look at you, trying to make excuses. Wouldn't anything be right for you?"

Heather hesitated behind them, hungry and shivering, clutching her stomach as if in pain. She trailed after them and peered into the kitchen to see what was happening.

Inside, Chef was making breakfast. Nilu had filtered tea, and bread was being toasted. The old man scolded Heather: "Standing around won't earn you wages. Work here first, then you'll get paid. Understand, girl?"

Heather's wet clothes dripped onto the floor. She squeezed them gently with her small hands, wringing some water out. Then, stepping forward, she quietly voiced, "What… what do I have to do?"

Kilu scented Heather's unwashed clothes and said sharply, "You stink. You've been in the rain and haven't changed yet? Go—change your clothes first, then come back!"

Chapter 4 : The Death

Heather didn't even know where she was.Dazed and trembling, stumbled back toward the first floor. The narrow corridor stretched ahead—a gauntlet of four rooms—before ending at the last one, the largest, where she and the other servants slept.

As she moved forward, she heard shouting from one of the rooms. She tried to peek inside, but the space was crowded—the doctor had arrived and was examining Riaa.

"Hurry! Bring hot water and mix the medicine quickly—we need to give it to Riaa now, or it'll be too late!" someone ordered.

Riaa lay on the bed, writhing in pain. Most of her clothes had been removed for cleaning, leaving only scraps covering her body. A nurse, working alongside the other girls, tended to her.

Heather stepped back, overwhelmed. People rushed past her in every direction. She didn't know where to go, where her clothes were, or even where her bag—with her spare clothes—had been kept. Huari had it last, using it to clean the blood.

Spotting Heather, Huari snapped, "Go get hot water, now!"

Panicked, Heather ran downstairs. The cook barely glanced at her when she stammered, "H-Hot water...?"

"Do it yourself!" he barked.

She froze—how was she supposed to heat the water?

Lilu, standing near the stove, sighed. "Here, take this." He shoved a pot at her. "Fill it and bring it back. Fast."

She scrambled to fill it with drinking water, but in her haste, she spilled half of it on the floor.

"Clean this mess up, girl!" Milu yelled.

"Take this first!" Lilu ordered, handing her the pot. "Then clean."

The water heated quickly—it was drinking water, after all. Heather rushed back upstairs, heart pounding. What if something happened to Riaa?

The hallway was packed. No one noticed her as she slipped past, carefully balancing the pot. Inside the room, she saw medicine vials scattered on the table.

Huari grabbed her arm. "Clean those rags over there—I'm mixing the medicine. Hurry!"

For Heather, every second was a struggle. Both of them were stretched

thin—time was running out.

Heather stepped forward. Though soaked and exhausted, she refused to give in. She moved toward Riaa and gently felt her body—blood was quietly seeping from the wound. Riaa tried to speak. Heather's hands, warm despite her own hunger, stroked Riaa's cheeks as she looked into her friend's face.

Hauri quickly brought over the medicine and pressed it to Riaa's lips. A nurse stood by with an injection syringe and IV tubes—the kind Riaa desperately needed. Her heartbeat was barely there, her breathing shallow.

"She's not breathing!" someone shouted.

Hauri lifted Riaa's head into her lap and murmured, "Just hold on... just a little longer—we'll do something soon." But uncertainty clouded her voice; perhaps the medicine was causing complications. With Riaa lying flat, Hauri had gently propped her up.

At that moment, the doctor, responding to the urgent call, rushed in. "What's happening? This can't be! Sit her up right now." He moved forward and lifted Riaa's clothes from her waist—her wound had reopened painful and deep. He grabbed a needle and thread, preparing to stitch her wound back together.

"Hurry!" Hauri urged, holding Riaa tightly as her friend trembled in her grasp, every heartbeat quick and erratic. Tears slid from Hauri's eyes as they both locked gazes. Through her tears, Heather watched in horror.

The doctor carefully inserted the needle and began suturing. Hauri blew air into Riaa's mouth, doing rescue breaths. The nurse cried out, "Doctor! Her pulse is dangerously low—please check now!"

He replied gravely, "Start compressions. If the bleeding doesn't stop, we won't save her. Move fast."

They moved aside her clothes and began chest compressions. Hauri screamed, "You're going to make it! Just a bit more—hold on!" But Riaa's body lay limp, motionless.

The nurse pressed her ear against Riaa's chest, listening for any pulse. There was none. She stumbled back. The doctor straightened, his face pale—exhausted.

Hauri screamed, "Stay with me… please! Don't leave…" Tears poured down her face as she held Riaa's hand.

The doctor leaned in one final time, closing his eyes and focusing all his strength and hope into that last attempt…